PART V · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2

Cadences

A phrase is a musical sentence, and it needs punctuation. The last two chords of a phrase are its **cadence**. They tell you: finished, taking a breath, or surprise!

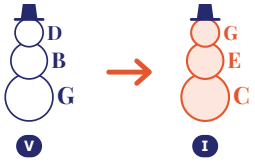
THE SECRET

Music has full stops and commas too: listen to the last two chords of a phrase.

.

Perfect

V → I

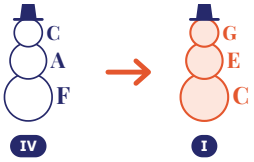


Home. The end.

Amen

Plagal

IV → I

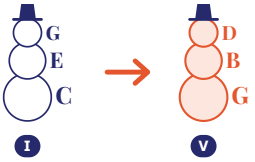


A soft, gentle end.

,

Imperfect

… → V

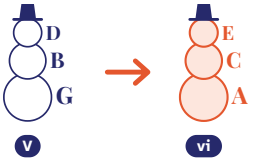


To be continued…

?!

Interrupted

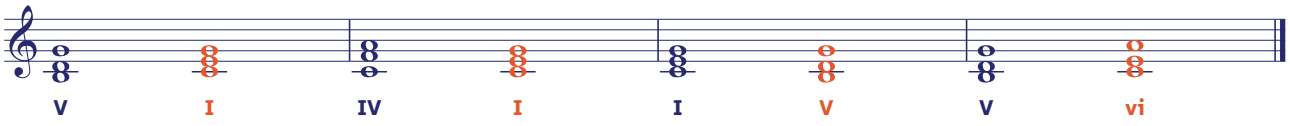
V → vi



Surprise! Not home.

1. Find the end of a phrase: often a long note, or a breath.
2. Name its **last two chords** with numerals: V I, IV I, anything then V, or V vi.
3. Match the punctuation: full stop (.), Amen, comma (,) or ?!

The four cadences in C

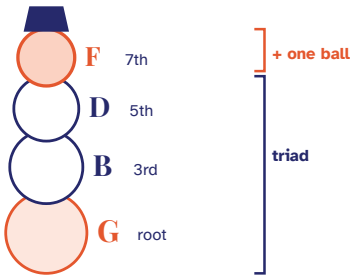


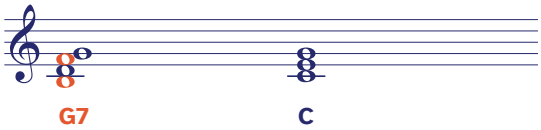
Perfect, plagal, imperfect, interrupted. The red chord is where each one lands.

CADENCE	CHORDS	FEELS LIKE	ALSO CALLED
Perfect	V → I	a full stop: finished	authentic, full close
Plagal	IV → I	the “A-men” sung at the end of a song in church	Amen cadence
Imperfect	any → V	a comma: waiting	half close, half cadence
Interrupted	V → vi	a surprise: not home yet	deceptive

PART V · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2 · CONTINUED

Why G7 pulls home





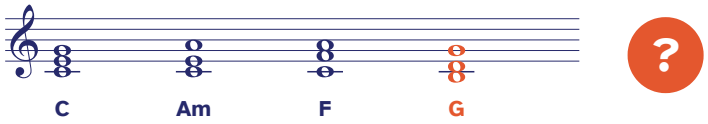
Add the 7th to V and the full stop gets stronger.

In **G7** two notes lean towards C major. The **B** rises to **C**, the **F** falls to **E**: each to the very next key, no key between. Two tiny steps, and you are home (Seventh chords, p. 99).

It works like a guest: B pushes up, F sighs down (p. 113).

EXAMPLE 1

How does this phrase end? C Am F G



1. **Find the last two chords** of the phrase.
2. **Turn them into numerals** in C major.
3. **Which punctuation card** ends that way?

F then G is IV → V: it lands on V, the comma. An **imperfect cadence**.

EXAMPLE 2

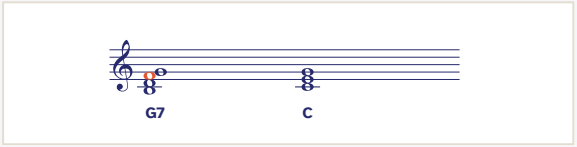
How does Twinkle end?



1. **The last two chords** of Twinkle in C are G, then C.
2. **Turn them into numerals.**
3. **Which card** goes from that chord to that chord?

V → I: a **perfect cadence**, the full stop. That is why Twinkle sounds finished.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



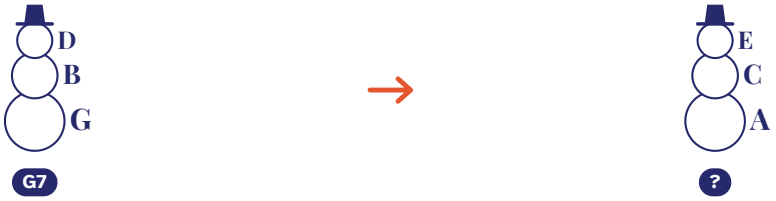
Play G7, then C. The end!

Now play G7, then A minor: “huh?!” That is the interrupted cadence. Then play F, then C, and sing “A-men”.

PART V · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Surprise! G7, then A minor

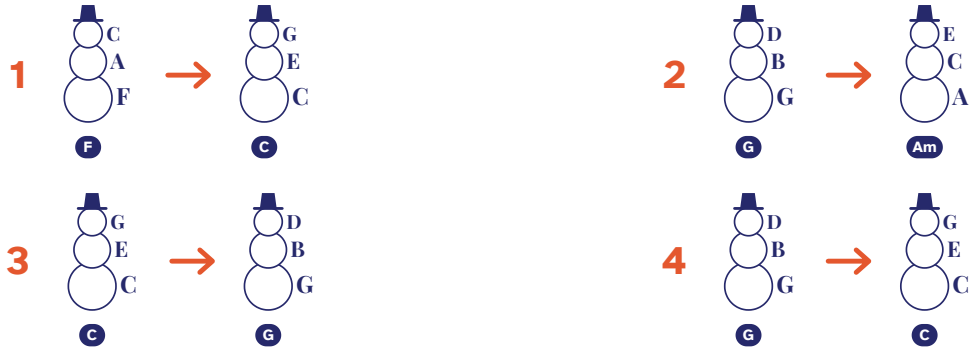


1. **G7 leans towards home**: you expect C.
2. **But the next chord is A minor.** Which numeral is it in C?
3. **V → that numeral:** which card?

V → vi: an **interrupted cadence**. The music was heading home, then turned the corner.

GAME

Punctuate the phrases



Each pair ends a phrase in C major. Turn the letters into numerals first (C is I, F is IV, G is V, Am is vi), then write full stop, comma, Amen or ?! beside each.

Answer: 1 Amen (plagal), 2 ?! (interrupted), 3 comma (imperfect), 4 full stop (perfect).

THINK OF IT Punctuation in a sentence: a full stop ends it, a comma makes you wait, and a surprise makes you gasp. Music ends its phrases the same way.

TRAP

- × Calling every ending on I (C) perfect: a perfect cadence comes **from V**. F to C is plagal.
- × Mixing up imperfect and perfect: imperfect **ends on** V; perfect **starts on** V and lands on I.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 93 · Seventh chords p. 99 · Chords under a melody p. 119

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 10 · Online: Library › Cadences